

Anise seeds' antispasmodic properties make them helpful in countering period pain, asthma, whooping cough, and bronchitis. The seeds' expectorant action justifies their use for these respiratory ailments. Anise seeds are thought to increase breast-milk production and may be beneficial in treating impotence and frigidity. Anise essential oil is used for similar complaints, and is also used externally to treat lice and scabies.

Research Anise essential oil has been shown to have significant antifungal activity, including against *Candida albicans*.

Cautions Do not take anise essential oil internally except under professional supervision.

Do not take anise during pregnancy, except in amounts normally used in cooking.

Self-help Uses **Acidity & indigestion**, p. 307; **Digestive upsets, gas & colic**, p. 318; **Stomach spasm**, p. 305; **Gas & bloating**, p. 306.



Seeds



Anise seeds, which benefit digestion, are harvested when ripe in autumn.

Pinguicula vulgaris (Lentibulariaceae) Butterwort

Description Insectivorous perennial growing to 4 in (10 cm). Has fleshy leaves in a basal rosette and double-lipped, purple-blue flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to northern and western Europe, butterwort grows in moorland and on mountains. The leaves are gathered in midsummer.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Butterwort contains mucilage, tannins, benzoic acid, cinnamic acid, and valeric acid. Cinnamic acid has antispasmodic properties.

History & Folklore Butterwort was much used in Welsh herbal medicine as a purgative. In Norway, the plant has been used to curdle reindeer milk, and medicinally, to treat wounds and ringworm.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Butterwort is little employed in European herbal medicine today. Its main use is as a cough remedy, with properties similar to those of sundew (*Drosera rotundifolia*, p. 203), another insect-eating plant. Butterwort may be used to treat chronic and convulsive coughs.

Related Species The similar *P. grandiflora*, native to the Pyrenees, has been used to treat spasmodic coughs.

⚠ Caution Take butterwort only under professional supervision.

Pinus sylvestris (Pinaceae) Scots Pine

Description Coniferous tree growing to 100 ft (30 m). Has reddish-brown bark, pairs of fine, needle-like leaves, yellowish buds in winter, and oval to conical cones.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to mountainous regions of Europe and north and west Asia, Scots pine is now found throughout the northern hemisphere. The leaves are gathered in summer. The stems are usually harvested when the tree is felled.

Parts Used Leaves, branches, stems, seeds, essential oil.

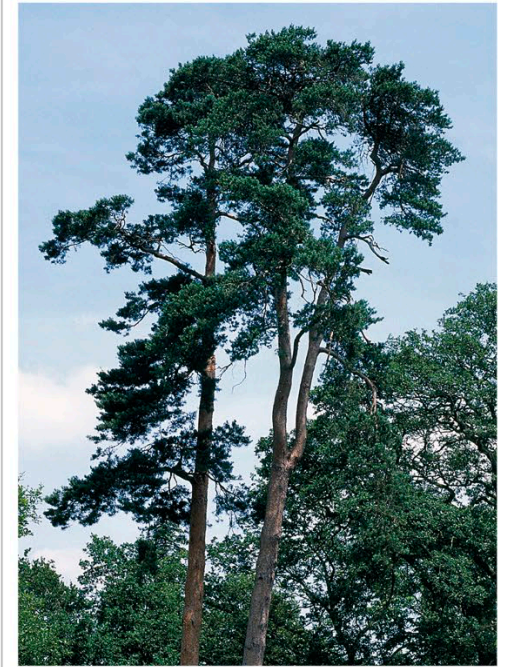
Constituents The leaves of Scots pine contain a volatile oil (consisting mainly of alpha-pinene), resin, and bitter principles.

History & Folklore Pine oil is added to disinfectants and other preparations. The distilled resin produces turpentine.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Scots pine leaves, taken internally, have a mildly antiseptic effect within the chest, and may also be used for arthritic and rheumatic problems. Essential oil from the leaves

may be taken for asthma, bronchitis, and other respiratory infections, and for digestive disorders such as gas. Scots pine branches and stems yield a thick resin, which is also antiseptic within the respiratory tract. The seeds yield an essential oil with diuretic and respiratory-stimulant properties.

Cautions Do not use Scots pine if prone to allergic skin reactions. Do not take the essential oil internally except under professional supervision.



Scots pine leaves, seeds, and oil have a mildly antiseptic effect within the respiratory and urinary tracts.

Piper angustifolia (Piperaceae) Matico

Description Perennial shrub reaching 23 ft (7 m). Has deeply veined aromatic lance-shaped leaves, spikes of tiny yellow flowers, and small black fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Matico is native to mountainous regions of Bolivia, Peru, and Ecuador. It is found in the wild and widely cultivated in these and other countries in tropical South America. The leaves are gathered throughout the year.

Parts Used Leaves.

Constituents Matico contains a volatile oil (including camphor, borneol, and azulene), alkaloids, tannins, mucilage, and resins.

History & Folklore Matico was and is used by Andean and Amazonian people as a wound-healing remedy and urinary antiseptic. European settlers learned of it in the 19th century and it became an official drug in some South American pharmacopoeias.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Matico is an aromatic stimulant, diuretic, and astringent used extensively for gastric and intestinal problems, including peptic ulcers, diarrhea and dysentery.